

SIGNIFICANCE AND DECLINE OF MAURYAN RULE

Scale and legacy | contraction and dynasty | evidence-ranked multi-causality

MASTER ANSWER LINE: unprecedented but differentiated integration; uneven contraction; selective transformation.

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THREE DIFFERENT HISTORICAL OBJECTS

- 1 IMPERIAL CONTRACTION = uneven loss of territorial coordination
- 2 DYNASTIC END = replacement of Mauryan kingship at Pataliputra
- 3 REGIONAL TRANSFORMATION = routes, towns, crafts and institutions persist or change

ANSWER LINE: 232 BCE marks Ashoka's death, not one synchronous collapse.

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SOURCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE

- 1 Ashokan edicts: peak royal voice; intention is clearer than compliance
- 2 Dasharatha inscriptions: secure later-Maurya patronage, not a territorial survey
- 3 Archaeology/coins: material and circulation patterns; attribution and dating matter
- 4 Puranic, Buddhist, Jain and Harshacharita narratives: later, divergent and source-qualified

ANSWER LINE: Every decline claim must pass evidence -> mechanism -> chronology -> region -> limit.

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IMPERIAL SCALE, INTEGRATION AND LIMITS

First 'virtually subcontinental' empire: Magadhan core + provincial nodes + corridors

Pataliputra, Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri represent reconstructed strategic nodes

Southern polities named by Ashoka are neighbours/audiences, not demonstrated uniform provinces

ANSWER LINE: Unprecedented integration did not equal a modern unitary nation-state.

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ADMINISTRATION AND COMMUNICATION

King/court + mahamattas + pradeshikas + rajukas + yuktas

Tours, reports, revenue, justice, military capacity and local intermediaries

Roads, rivers, messengers and oral proclamation carried policy over distance

ANSWER LINE: The same network created state capacity and exposed the empire to latency and centre-agent gaps.

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INSCRIPTIONAL GOVERNANCE, SCRIPTS AND AUDIENCES

- 1 Prakrit-Brahmi across much of the imperial field
- 2 Kharoshthi in the north-west; Greek and Aramaic in selected frontier settings
- 3 Rock/pillar edicts made ethics, administration and kingship durably public

ANSWER LINE: Linguistic adaptation shows negotiated communication, not ethnicity, mass literacy or equal control.

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DHAMMA AND PUBLIC ETHICS

Non-injury, restraint, welfare, humane treatment and sectarian concord

Rock Edict XII: restraint in sectarian praise/blame; Rock Edict XIII: remorse and dhamma-vijaya

Buddhist-rooted but wider than Buddhist doctrine; paternal and hierarchical

ANSWER LINE: Dhamma reoriented legitimacy while army, punishment and deterrence remained.

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ECONOMY, AGRICULTURE, ROUTES AND URBANISATION

- 1 Agrarian revenue + irrigation + settlement + roads/rivers + crafts/towns + strategic resources
- 2 Punch-marked coins show circulation in contexts, not a uniform monetised economy or GDP
- 3 Arthashastra controls and monopolies are prescriptive; urbanisation predates and outlives the dynasty

ANSWER LINE: Mauryan political economy combined extraction and facilitation, with major regional variation.

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ART, ARCHITECTURE AND CULTURAL INTERACTION

- 1 Polished pillars/capitals + Barabar caves + Sanchi's Mauryan brick core
- 2 Sarnath lion capital acquired a later republican-national meaning
- 3 Sanchi's Shunga enlargement and Satavahana gateways show continuity through transformation

ANSWER LINE: Mauryan legacy is innovation plus interaction plus later reuse, not unchanged institutional survival.

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POST-ASHOKA SUCCESSION AND TERMINAL EVENT

232 BCE: Ashoka dies; Dasharatha is the clearest inscriptionally attested later Maurya

Kunala, Samprati, Salisuka, Devavarman and Satadhanvan vary across later traditions

Brihadratha/Pushyamitra army-review story is transmitted by the much later Harshacharita

ANSWER LINE: State the dynastic end conventionally as c. 187/185 BCE and avoid false year-by-year precision.

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10 STRONGER DECLINE MECHANISMS

Short reigns/succession shocks -> unstable command, appointments and provincial loyalty

Scale/communication -> delayed fiscal and military response across differentiated regions

Provincial assertion -> local elites redirect revenue, troops and legitimacy

Bactrian Greek pressure -> north-western frontier loss and strategic-route competition

ANSWER LINE: Each mechanism explains a part of the contraction; none alone explains all regions.

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FISCAL, OPPRESSION AND MATERIAL-ECONOMIC CLAIMS

- 1 Large army and officialdom make fiscal strain plausible, but no bankruptcy archive survives
- 2 Taxila complaints are later Buddhist memory; Kalinga edicts directly show concern over unjust officers
- 3 Coin debasement/urban decline require dated metallurgical and site-specific sequences

ANSWER LINE: Upinder Singh finds no proof of either a Mauryan state fiscal crisis or a general economic crisis.

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REJECTED OR QUALIFIED MONOCAUSAL THEORIES

PACIFISM: no army disbandment; forest warning and capital punishment remain

BRAHMANICAL REACTION: possible local grievance, but Ashoka honours Brahmanas and shramanas

BUDDHIST EXPENDITURE: hagiographic donation stories are not treasury accounts

ECOLOGICAL COLLAPSE: ecology shaped costs; no dated terminal shock is established

ANSWER LINE: The Brihadratha-Pushyamitra event establishes dynastic replacement more securely than its alleged cause.

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HISTORIOGRAPHY: POSITION, EVIDENCE, LIMIT

- 1 H.C. Raychaudhuri: criticism of Ashoka's peace policy; older political-military frame
- 2 D.D. Kosambi: materialist method; do not invent a specific single-cause Mauryan thesis
- 3 R.S. Sharma: fiscal burden, oppression, diffusion, reaction and frontier hypotheses
- 4 Romila Thapar / Upinder Singh: structural, ideological, regional and source-ranked analysis

ANSWER LINE: A historian's name earns marks only when tied to an accurate position and evidentiary limit.

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MULTI-CAUSAL FEEDBACK AND REGIONAL TRANSITION

Succession uncertainty -> weaker compliance/revenue -> reduced coordination -> more regional assertion

Ganga-centre: Shunga/Kanva sequence; north-west: Indo-Greek authority; Deccan: Satavahana emergence

Sovereignty fragmented while routes, towns, scripts, cults, crafts and patronage were recombined

ANSWER LINE: Mauryan integration contracted unevenly; the dynasty ended, but regional transformation was not civilisational collapse.

UPSC TRAPS: 232 BCE ≠ dynastic end | edict reach ≠ uniform rule | fragmentation ≠ total economic collapse

QUALIFIED VERDICT: no single-cause collapse; distinguish imperial contraction, dynasty end and regional transformation.